> poured in a murderous fire from every rock and cave in the heights on each side, but descended into the Pass and slew man, woman and child. The whole road for a distance of 5 miles was covered with dead and dying. The 37th Native Infantry lost more than half its men, and other Corps in proportion. Even those who remained could scarcely move from their feet and hands being frost-bitten, and to add to our misery, snow began to fall on our arrival at Khoord Cabul.[42]

All morning, Lawrence and Mackenzie had to sit with Akbar and make small talk, listening as the waves of musketry echoed down the pass. Mackenzie, who was a good linguist, heard Akbar shouting to his men in Dari – a language known to many of the British – to 'spare' the British, while telling them to 'slay them all' in Pashtu, the language of the tribes, which only Mackenzie and very few others on the British side understood. In the late afternoon the two hostages were allowed to follow, captives again as they had been on the day of Macnaghten's murder, but this time protected by Akbar's cousin, Sultan Jan Barakzai. The scene the party passed was one of unparalleled horror. As Lawrence described it:

> sepoys and camp followers were being stripped and plundered on all sides, and such as refused to give up their money and valuables were instantly stabbed or cut down . . . On seeing us, the poor creatures cried out for help, many of them recognising me and calling me by name. But what could we do . . . The Ghilzais had now tasted blood, and clearly showed their tigerish nature, becoming very savage and fierce in their demeanour towards ourselves, demanding that we should be given up to them for a sacrifice, brandishing their long blood-stained knives in our faces, and telling us 'to look on the heaps of the carcasses around us, as we should soon be ourselves among them.' 'You came to Kabul for fruit, did you? How do you like it now?' they cried.

When he saw the body of an Englishman stretched out by the road, Lawrence rode over and found that the soldier was alive:

> the poor fellow raising his head and recognising me, cried out, 'For God sake, Captain Lawrence, don't leave me here!' I jumped off my horse, and going up to the man raised him up, with the assistance of two of Sultan Jan's men, who had dismounted by his orders. He was a sergeant of the 44th, and at first appeared only to have lost his left hand; but to my grief and horror, on raising him, I saw that from the nape of his neck to his backbone, he had been cut in pieces. 'What use is there lifting him up?' cried the Affghans, 'he cannot live many minutes.' I reluctantly assented, and on telling the poor fellow we could do nothing for him, he said, 'Then for God sake shoot me.' 'Even this I cannot do,' I mournfully replied. 'Then leave me to die,' he said, and this we were forced to do . . .
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> As we proceeded we met numbers of the enemy's horse and foot returning to Kabul, laden with plunder of all kinds. One miscreant had a little Indian girl seated on his horse behind him . . .[43]